

Two Wolves

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Introduction

Since 2023, the Arizona Diamondbacks have become one of the most explosive and fun teams in the MLB. The star power of Ketel Marte and Corbin Carroll anchors a very potent offense. Despite their offensive brilliance, the Diamondbacks missed the postseason in both 2024 and 2025. Unfortunately for Arizona, there are two sides of the diamond, and their pitching has consistently let them down. Specifically, the Arizona bullpen has remained a weakness:

No Relief	Bullpen WAR	Rank
2023	2.2	23
2024	2.2	22
2025	-0.3	28
2026 (thru 5/10)	0.6	19

Figure 1: The Diamondbacks' Below Average Bullpen

Without a consistent or reliable bullpen, the Diamondbacks became notorious for repeatedly blowing leads. If they wanted to win, they were required to outgun their opponent.

The Diamondbacks have tried to strengthen their bullpen, mostly through young arms in their farm system. However, most of those young arms have disappointed, gotten injured, or simply pitched badly. There is one man who has met all the criteria depending on the season. Since 2023, he has pitched the most innings out of the pen for the Diamondbacks by far. Meet the subject of this piece: Kevin Ginkel, whose year-to-year production mirrors his team's struggles and makes for a difficult statistical assessment.

The Rock

2023 was Kevin Ginkel's breakout season, while also being his age-29 season. It took four seasons for Ginkel to become established. 2019 to 2022 were spent shuffling between the minor leagues, dealing with injuries, and of course, the COVID season. Ginkel struggled with walks, but his 2022 season was resurgent and a step in the right direction. He was healthy, he posted a career-low *FIP*, and his *ERA* was under six. His *WHIP* was still higher than one would like. There was a wide gap between his

Earning My Keep	IP	ERA	FIP	WHIP	K%	BB%	ERA-	FIP-	xFIP-
2019	24.1	1.48	3.09	0.986	29.2%	9.4%	33	71	90
2020	16.0	6.75	5.82	2.125	22.8%	16.5%	149	133	138
2021	28.1	6.35	5.89	1.553	24.0%	10.9%	151	144	110
2022	29.1	3.38	2.74	1.295	24.2%	8.9%	82	71	90

Figure 2: Ginkel's First Four Seasons

FIP- (71) and his *WHIP+* (101¹). If Ginkel could effectively limit on base traffic, he would finally put it together, and that's exactly what he did in 2023.

IP	ERA	FIP	WHIP	K%	BB%	ERA-	FIP-	xFIP-
65.1	2.48	2.86	0.980	27.6%	9.1%	56	68	82

Figure 3: The 2023 Breakout

It's glorious. Kevin Ginkel became a trusted arm of a World Series bound team. He wasn't the closer (4 saves in 60 games); he was more of a "setup man," acting as a late-inning reliever. He set career highs in innings, *FIP-*, and *xFIP*, cementing himself as one of the top relief pitchers in the MLB. Ginkel was especially dominant in the postseason: 11 2/3 innings pitched, 8 hits, 5 walks, 15 strikeouts, 0 RUNS, 0 XBH. Despite the tough ending for the Diamondbacks, Ginkel had an incredible individual season.

2024 was a victory lap for Kevin. He combined continued health with his newfound status to have another strong campaign.

IP	ERA	FIP	WHIP	K%	BB%	ERA-	FIP-	xFIP-
70.0	3.21	2.85	1.200	26.5%	5.2%	77	73	80

Figure 4: Ginkel's 2024 Season

Unlike Ginkel, the Diamondbacks took a step back as a team in 2024. Despite an improved record, the Diamondbacks finished the season 14-17 and missed the postseason. It was a very frustrating follow up campaign. But enough about that.

There are a few arguments for why Ginkel's 2024 campaign was better than his 2023 breakout year. To compare the two seasons, I'm going to introduce another advanced stat that is lauded as a stronger indicator of performance than *xFIP*: *SIERA* (Figure 5). Despite nearly halving his walk rate, Ginkel allowed more hits and home runs in 2024. However, both his *xFIP* and *SIERA* took a large dip in 2024. Personally, I am partial to Ginkel's 2023 season because of his dominance in the postseason, but it's hard to argue against a *SIERA* that placed Ginkel in elite status.

¹Note: A lower *WHIP+* is better, but that is typically not the case for plus stats.

Encore!	2023	2024
WHIP	0.980	1.200
HR%	1.2%	2.1%
K% - BB%	18.5%	21.3%
xFIP	3.60	3.23
SIERA	3.46	2.97

Figure 5: Ginkel's Two-Year Dominance

Unfortunately for Kevin, his fortune would take a turn for the worst.

Hard Times

In 2025, both Ginkel and his Diamondbacks had a difficult season. The Diamondbacks won seven less games in 2025, going from 89-73 to 82-80. They were sellers at the deadline, offloading Josh Naylor, Eugenio Suárez, Shelby Miller, etc. They made a late run to try and sneak into the Wild Card, but it was too little, too late. As for Ginkel himself, it was even more rough.

IP	ERA	FIP	WHIP	K%	BB%	ERA-	FIP-	xFIP-
25.2	7.36	3.64	1.636	24.0%	10.7%	173	91	108

Figure 6: Tough times for the Ginkster

This season mirrored his miserable 2021 season; Ginkel battled a right shoulder injury, had an ERA north of seven, his walk rate was over ten, and his WHIP was closer to two than it was to one. Ginkel consistently allowed the bases to be full of traffic. You'll notice his innings were way down, too; Ginkel was demoted to AAA due to his performance, and he suffered a season-ending injury shortly after. A nightmare season on two fronts.

However, there are layers to Ginkel's troubles. You'll notice that his *FIP* was less than half of his *ERA*. In fact, Ginkel had the largest difference in *ERA* – *FIP* in the MLB among relief pitchers with at least 20 innings. Does this mean that Kevin was getting unlucky in 2025? That question was more complicated to answer than I expected, and it's going to require introducing more stats to adequately address all perspectives.

Argument I: BABIP

In 2025, Kevin Ginkel had a .360 *BABIP*. This placed him among the top-20 out of 325 relievers with at least 20 innings (Note: for the rest of the coverage about Ginkel's 2025 rankings, assume it is among relievers with at least 20 innings). Given that the range for sustainable *BABIP* is between .250 and .350 along with the fact that *BABIP* is used to evaluate how well a pitcher's defense is playing, then Ginkel was definitely getting unlucky, right? If he could have pitched more innings, his *BABIP* would have dropped and his *ERA* would have subsequently decreased.

I disagree with this analysis; I think it's reductive. First, the Diamondbacks defense was not poor by any stretch in 2025. On FanGraphs, they ranked eleventh in Defensive Runs Above Average, placing them just outside the elite tier. Second, focusing on Ginkel's *BABIP* buries the lead; his walk rate doubled compared to 2025, and his *BABIP* in 2024 was not that much lower (.332).

Argument II: Stranding Runners

An important part of pitching is getting out of jams. If there are runners on base, make sure they don't come around to score. Don't make a bad situation worse. A prime example is the work of [Tyler Matzek in the 2021 postseason](#). There's a stat that assesses how often a pitcher strands runners: Left On Base percentage, or *LOB%*. Even in Ginkel's best seasons, he was never elite at stranding runners. The FanGraphs article states that *LOB%* is best assessed with *BABIP* and how often an induced fly ball becomes a home run, *HR/FB%*.

Season	LOB%	LOB%+	HR/FB%	HR/FB%-	BABIP	BABIP-
2023	68.0%	94	5.7%	47	0.244	81
2024	71.2%	99	8.7%	79	0.332	111
2025	53.4%	75	6.5%	59	0.360	125

Figure 7: Stranding Runners

To interpret this graph, in Ginkel's best seasons, he was slightly below average when it came to stranding runners. The typical average usually falls within 70-72%. Ginkel's 2025 season was a disaster; half of runners on base came around to score on Ginkel's watch. This was doubly odd because of his [2023 postseason](#); Ginkel got out of numerous jams: Game 2 of the Wild Card, Game 7 of the NLCS, and Game 5 of the World Series. Ginkel's *BABIP* took a leap in 2025, but not that big of a leaf. He also allowed less home runs in 2025; his home run/fly ball ratio was elite. There has to be more at play, because an extremely low *HR/FB%* paired with a slightly worse, albeit unlucky *BABIP* does not read like a recipe for one of the worst *LOB* percentages in the league. Ginkel was likely getting unlucky, but I argue he got knocked around in 2025.

Argument III: Contact

There is a picture that is becoming clearer. A huge jump in *WHIP*, a huge jump in walks, the inability to strand runners: Ginkel couldn't locate his pitches. He was missing not only in terms of throwing strikes; he was missing with the strikes he was throwing:

Season	Location+	xwOBA	xwOBACon	xSLG	HardHit%
2023	108	0.273	0.326	0.336	37.1%
2024	112	0.283	0.357	0.367	40.8%
2025	102	0.330	0.384	0.412	45.5%

Figure 8: Kevin Ginkel getting knocked around

This isn't "bad luck." Ginkel couldn't locate his pitches and it led to him allowing much better contact from opposing batters. His 2024 season featured a smaller rise in contact quality, but his ability to throw strikes compensated for it. He got the worst of both worlds in 2025.

After everything we've seen, what was Ginkel's *SIERA* in 2025? After the struggles locating pitches, allowing quality contact on a consistent basis, this is his final test to best determine if Ginkel was unlucky:

Season	SIERA	SIERA-
2023	3.46	84
2024	2.97	79
2025	3.94	100

Figure 9: Ginkel's *SIERA* from 2023-25

After all that, Ginkel's *SIERA* was...average? He definitely took a massive step back from 2023 and 2024, but that's still a far cry from having an *ERA* above seven. However, the outlook on the future isn't great. Ginkel had a miserable season and suffered a long term injury, so you would hope the only direction is up from here.

We're Back...?

2026 has simultaneously been a return to form and revealing for the now 32-year-old reliever:

IP	ERA	FIP	WHIP	K%	BB%	ERA-	FIP-	xFIP-
16.0	3.94	2.32	1.250	27.9%	5.9%	95	59	72

Figure 10: Ginkel's 2026 (as of May 10)

Despite having *ERA* and *WHIP* that are higher than ideal, Ginkel has had a resurgent season so far. Advanced stats love him, even more than usual (Figures 10 and 11). He currently has career benchmarks in many crucial stats (*SIERA*, *K%*, *K% - BB%*, *FIP*, *xFIP*, *xwOBA*, *xwOBACon*, *xSLG*).

SIERA	SIERA-	Location+	xwOBA	xwOBACon	xSLG	HardHit%
2.67	73	111	0.263	0.352	0.328	42.2%

Figure 11: Ginkel's *SIERA* and contact stats in 2026

Not only has he bounced back from his 2025 nightmare, he's come back stronger. Is Ginkel back? Yes and no. That question is not as straightforward as one might expect.

What Kind of Stuff?

Kevin Ginkel is having a career year in strikeout rate. Knowing that, it would be logical to assume that he has elite "stuff." He ranks in the top half of the league in whiff

rate. However, Ginkel does not have elite stuff; he never has, but his pitch arsenal has declined since his two-year peak:

	Fastball			Slider			Sinker		
	Pitch%	RV/100	Stuff+	Pitch%	RV/100	Stuff+	Pitch%	RV/100	Stuff+
2023	46.0%	0.9	81	43.0%	1.8	111	11.0%	3.8	96
2024	52.7%	0.2	84	38.4%	0.3	110	8.9%	0.2	97
2025	50.5%	-1.1	84	42.6%	0.2	99	6.9%	-5.4	96
2026	44.2%	-0.6	80	51.3%	2.6	101	4.5%	-6.8	88

Figure 12: Ginkel's Three Pitches

In 2023, Ginkel wielded a strong three-pitch mix. Three years later, Ginkel's sinker is rarely thrown and crushed whenever it is, and his fastball has declined. Ginkel's strongest pitcher, his slider, has suffered a decline in movement. He went from three effective pitches to just one. The lower Stuff+ could be a residual effect of his severe shoulder injury in the previous year.

However, there is a very silver lining. Looking at these numbers begs the question: if Ginkel had one positive pitch, how is he on pace for a career year by several advanced metrics? These numbers suggest that his arm is cooked, but his *SIERA* and contact rates have been outstanding. How can that be?

Pinpoint

Ginkel had issues locating pitches in 2023 and especially 2025. His 2026 season thus far has been a complete 180.

Surgical	K - BB%	BB%	Location+	O-Swing%
Stat	22.1%	5.9%	111	36.3%
Percentile	87	82	92	76

Figure 13: I thought he had a control problem?

Ginkel doesn't have elite stuff, but he has regained elite control. He isn't missing his spots, and that is more than compensating for his lack of elite movement. Plus, along with his elite contact rates, Ginkel is still fantastic at limiting home runs. If he is experiencing residual effects from his season-ending shoulder injury, this is a remarkable adjustment for Ginkel.

No Leverage

There's another part of Ginkel's recent career that I haven't understood. The Diamondbacks consistently field an unreliable bullpen (see Figure 1), and Ginkel is the longest tenured Diamondback reliever, while also having moments of brilliance, not limited to the 2023 postseason. Why hasn't Arizona converted Kevin Ginkel to the closer role? Justin Martinez won't be back until after the summer, and yet, the D-Backs insist on deploying the Human Heart Throb himself in Paul Sewald. Ginkel has just twelve saves since 2023.

There are some non-analytical reasons to consider: Ginkel's long term injury, Manager Torrey Lovullo liking where Ginkel is, etc. However, despite Ginkel's heroics in the 2023 postseason, his regular season performance in high leverage spots has been quite poor.

		In High Leverage Situations						
	gmLI	TBF	IP	ERA	WHIP	K%	BB%	LOB%
2023	1.00	28	7.1	4.91	1.091	28.6%	14.3%	-12.5%
2024	1.43	80	20.0	5.85	1.050	28.7%	6.3%	14.6%
2025	1.07	29	5.2	15.88	1.941	27.6%	13.8%	16.7%
2026	1.17	14	3.0	6.00	1.667	28.6%	7.1%	40.0%

Figure 14: Ginkel struggling in high leverage

It's like he's a completely different guy. The *LOB%* is particularly striking; Ginkel has the worst *LOB%* among relievers (Figure 15) in high leverage spots since 2023. His *BABIP* (.330) isn't outrageous and he still limits home runs. His walks are slightly inflated, but his overall walk rate in high leverage is about 9% since 2023. He limits walks and home runs, but still has a very high *WHIP* and *ERA*; Ginkel has struggled to limit base hits in high leverage situations.

However, once again, advanced metrics love Ginkel in high leverage situations. There is such a wide gap between the actual and peripheral stats that it's difficult to pin where the true Ginkel is:

Who Am I?	ERA	FIP	K - BB%	WHIP	LOB%	HR%	HardH%	wOBA
Stat	7.25	2.48	19.2%	1.250	13.2%	0.66%	28.3%	0.292
Percentile	8	92	72	45	0	95	62	42

Figure 15: Somewhere in the middle?

An *ERA* over 7 but a *FIP* below 2.50. I already established why Ginkel is a *FIP* darling: At his best, he limits walks, never allows home runs, and racks up strikeouts. There are two completely different sentiments expressed by these numbers. His sample size isn't insignificant (36 innings, 150 batters faced), but Ginkel's true high leverage pitching ability is likely somewhere in between his 2023 dominance and a 7.25 *ERA*.

Unlucky?	xFIP	BABIP	ERA - FIP	ERA - xFIP
Stat	3.40	0.330	4.77	3.85
Percentile	65	17	98	98

Figure 16: Unlucky? Maybe

Ginkel's allowed *BABIP* in high leverage situations is high. However, it is not so high that one could confidently conclude Ginkel is getting unlucky. Secondly, in Figure 7, it was shown that Ginkel maintained a .332 *BABIP* in 70 innings in 2024 and had a great season; his *LOB%* in 2024 was league average, while his *LOB%* in high leverage from 2023-26 is incomprehensibly low.

Ginkel's high leverage stats will likely converge in between the two extremes. In Figure 14, it's observed that Ginkel's allowed Hard Hit % and *wOBA* are both in the realm of average. He has a strong walk-strikeout contrast, but he still gives up to many hits to likely ever be elite in high leverage spots.

Concluding Remarks

It's been a wild three-year span for Kevin Ginkel. In 2023, he broke out as an elite bullpen arm and was untouchable in the postseason for a World Series team. Two years later, he battled a debilitating right shoulder injury and had an awful season. He's now healthy, having a resurgent season, and projects to be even better. Relief pitchers can have incredibly unpredictable careers; their peaks can be long or fleeting. After a thorough examination of Ginkel's recent career, here's my take: Kevin Ginkel is a reliable relief option. He strikes people out, limits the long ball, and has shown the ability to limit walks, especially recently. His 2025 injury appears to have greatly affected his slider's movement. He is held back by a lack of true elite stuff, which leaves him vulnerable to concede a lot of base hits. He does not have a deep pitch arsenal; combine that with the average stuff, he is more of a late inning "specialist" type than a true stopper or door closer for a bullpen. His performance in the 2023 postseason is as fine as you will see from a reliever, and it's a shame that it has become forgotten with his team losing in the end. Ginkel's game is not elite, but it is very solid, and it should age gracefully given his focus on location and not being reliant on velocity or movement.

Glossary

- **WHIP** = $\frac{Walks + Hits}{Innings\ Pitched}$
- **ERA** = $9 \times \frac{Earned\ Runs}{Innings\ Pitched}$
- **FIP**: Pitcher evaluation metric that only looks at outcomes independent of team defense: Home Runs, Walks, Hit by Pitch, Strikeouts. It's considered a better evaluation metric compared to ERA.
- **xFIP**: A pitcher's FIP, but the home runs are adjusted to match a baseline average of 10.5% of allowed fly balls. This can reveal if a pitcher was getting lucky or unlucky, but it can also highlight if a pitcher struggles with home run prevention.
- **BABIP**: Batting Average on Balls In Play;
Formula: $\frac{Hits - Home\ Runs}{At\ Bats - Strikeouts - Home\ Runs + Sac\ Flies}$
- **SIERA**: A new, new version of *ERA* that expands on *FIP* attempting to remove luck and quantify how good a pitcher is. While *FIP* and *xFIP* ignore balls in play and focus on just the four true outcomes, *SIERA* weighs balls in play to give more context to a pitcher's performance, and this is considered the strongest metric for predicting future pitcher performance.
- **gmLI**: Average leverage index of when a pitcher is in the game; 1 is average, higher means higher leverage.
- **Plus and Minus Stats**: Take any stat and adjust it relative to the league. 100 is average, and lower is better for minus stats (*FIP*-, for example) and higher is better for plus stats.

References

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